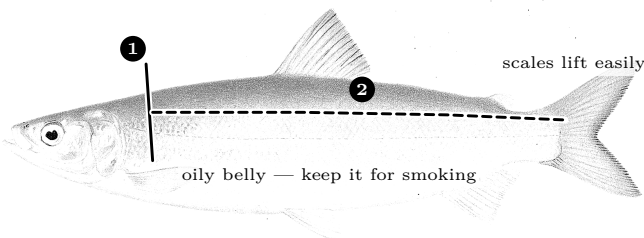


# Cooking Cisco

*Coregonus artedii* — in the kitchen

An oily, fine-fleshed fish that wants to be smoked



Cisco from Hemlock Lake — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Verdict</b>   | Excellent, but nothing like the others — rich, oily and fine-textured, closer to a small trout or a herring than to walleye. ●●●●○                                        |
| <b>Oil</b>       | High, and unusually so for these lakes. That is exactly why it smokes so well and why it does not keep long fresh.                                                        |
| <b>Handling</b>  | The most perishable fish in the guide. Bleed it and ice it within minutes or the oil turns. This is not fussiness — a cisco left warm for two hours is not worth cooking. |
| <b>Best size</b> | 10–14 in.                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Yield</b>     | About 40%, the best in the guide — a straightforward, thick-bodied fish with a small head.                                                                                |
| <b>Season</b>    | Late autumn and through the ice, when they are at their fattest. <i>see the <b>Cisco</b> sheet</i>                                                                        |

## Cleaning it

1. **Bleed it at the boat** — a cut through the gill arches — and put it straight on ice. This matters more for cisco than for anything else here.
2. **Scale it** if you are smoking or grilling skin-on. Cisco scales are large and lift with almost no effort.
3. **Gut it**, and for smoking leave the head on — it gives you something to hang it by.
4. **Or fillet normally:** behind the gill to the backbone, along the spine to the tail, ribs out. The flesh is soft, so use a sharp blade and few strokes.
5. **Leave the belly meat on.** It is the fattiest and best part, and it is what makes smoked cisco worth doing.

## Bones and what to watch for

|                     |                                                                                                                              |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Pin bones</b>    | A row of fine pin bones runs down the fillet. Pull them with needle-nose pliers, in the direction they lean, before cooking. |
| <b>Rib cage</b>     | Fine and soft.                                                                                                               |
| <b>Smoked whole</b> | The frame lifts out in one piece after smoking — another reason to smoke rather than fillet.                                 |
| <b>Soft flesh</b>   | Handle gently and do not stack.                                                                                              |

## Cooking it

| Method        | How                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Smoked        | The right answer. Brine six hours in salt, brown sugar and water. Air-dry until tacky — that skin, the pellicle, is what smoke sticks to. Cold-smoke over apple or alder at 180 °F for three to four hours. Outstanding, and it keeps. |
| Grilled whole | Scaled, gutted, scored, oiled and salted. Hot grill, four minutes a side. The oil bastes it from inside.                                                                                                                               |
| Pan-fried     | Fillets, skin on, skin-side down in a hot dry pan — there is enough fat in the fish that it needs almost no oil. Two minutes, flip, one minute.                                                                                        |

### The one fish here that rewards a smoker

Every other fish in this guide is lean, and lean fish smoke poorly — they go dry and stringy. Cisco is the exception, and a lake that holds them is unusual in this part of Wisconsin. If you have ever wanted a reason to build a smoker, a November cisco from Pine Lake is it. *see the **Cisco** sheet*

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**Wisconsin safe-eating guidance.** For all other species not listed as panfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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